Exposed, but adopting? Generative AI across economic divides

Lily Rudin · November 2, 2026

Generative AI has spread faster than almost any previous technology, but adoption is uneven across countries. This report asks two questions: does AI adoption follow existing economic divides, and are the countries whose workforces are most exposed to generative AI the ones adopting it least? It combines occupational employment data from the International Labour Organization (ILO), the OECD's survey of AI use by businesses, and World Bank income data.

1. Where is the workforce exposed?

The ILO's 2025 index scores each occupation by how many of its tasks generative AI could potentially perform. Clerical support work, such as data entry, bookkeeping and general office work, scores highest. *Exposure* measures that potential; it does not predict job loss, and the ILO expects most exposed jobs to be transformed rather than eliminated. Because clerical work is the clearest case, the first charts use its share of employment as a proxy for exposure.

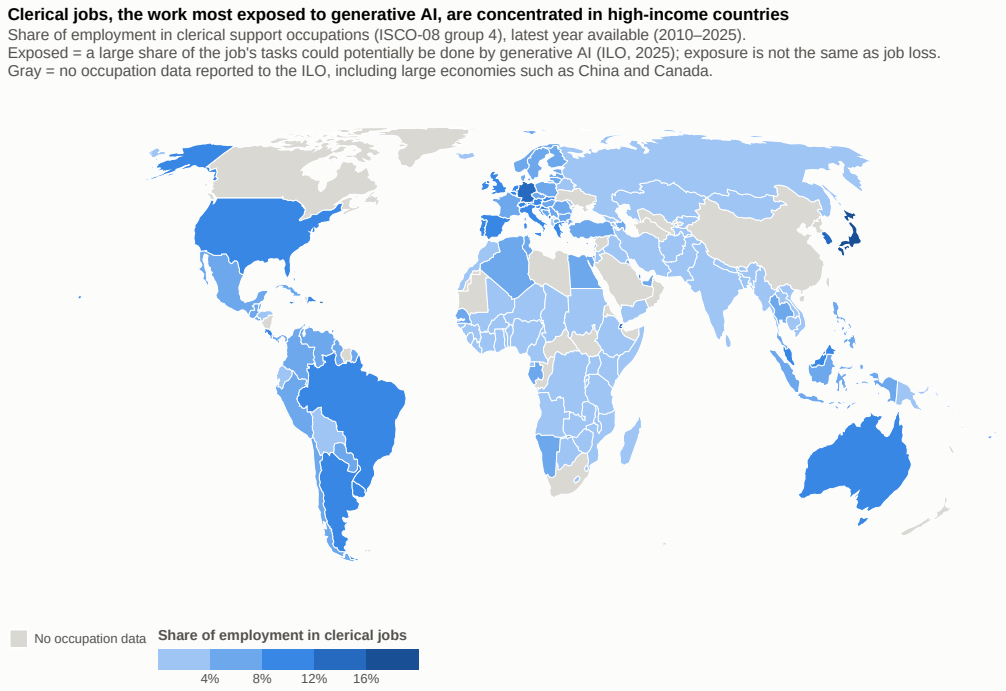


Figure 1. Clerical jobs make up a much larger share of employment in high-income countries in Europe, North America, East Asia and Oceania than in most of Africa and South Asia.
Source: ILOSTAT, employment by occupation (ISCO-08); ILO Working Paper 140 (2025).

The pattern follows a broader shift in what work looks like as countries get richer. In low-income countries, most people work in agriculture; in high-income countries, employment is concentrated in professional, technical and clerical occupations, which are exactly the jobs generative AI can reach. Clerical work alone rises from about 1% of employment in low-income countries to about 10% in

high-income ones.

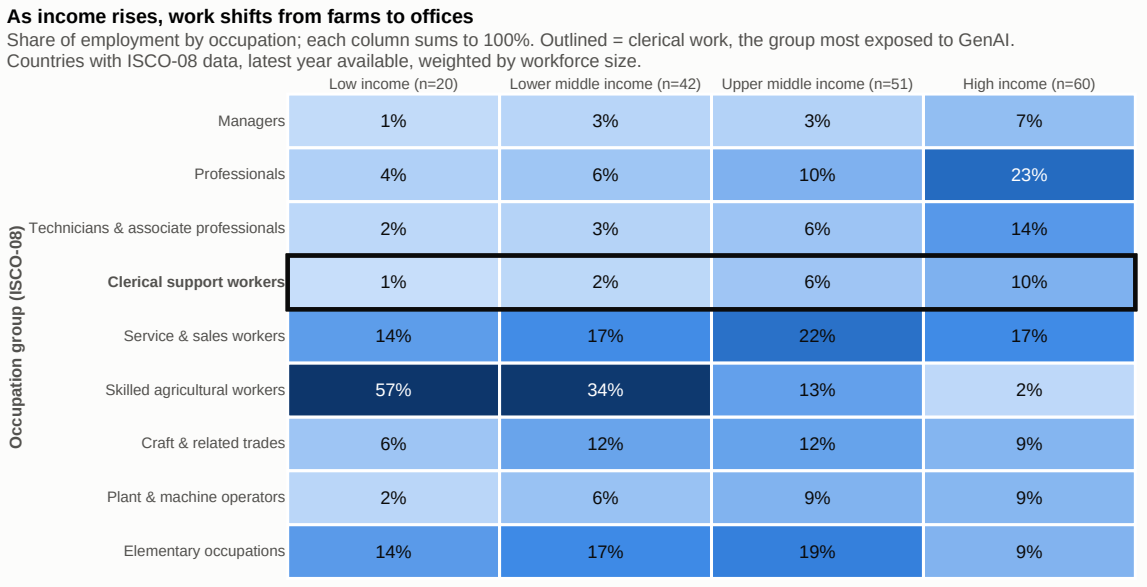


Figure 2. Agriculture falls from 57% of employment in low-income countries to 2% in high-income countries, while professional, technical and clerical work grows.
Source: ILOSTAT; World Bank income classifications.

Exposure is also unevenly distributed between women and men. In every economy shown, women are far more likely than men to work in clerical jobs. In the most extreme cases, around a quarter of employed women work in clerical roles, against well under a tenth of men.

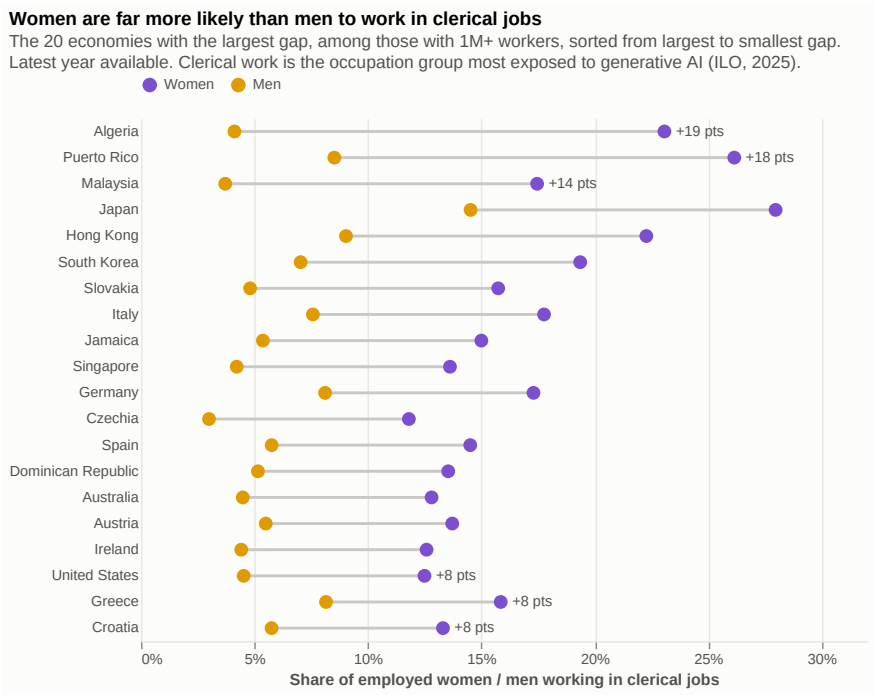


Figure 3. Women's share of employment in clerical jobs is several times men's in the economies with the largest gaps.
Source: ILOSTAT, employment by sex and occupation.

The difference between income groups is not a snapshot. Averaged across countries in each World Bank income group, the clerical share has stayed well apart between high- and low-income countries throughout 2012–2024.

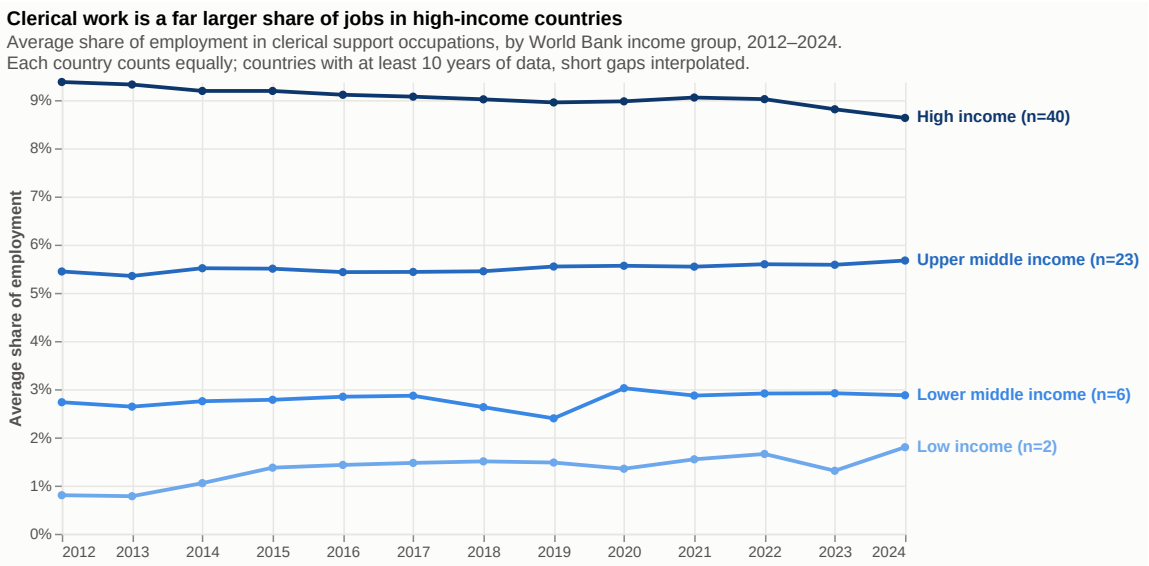


Figure 4. Average share of employment in clerical jobs by income group, 2012–2024.
Source: ILOSTAT; World Bank income classifications.

2. Who is adopting AI?

Business adoption varies enormously, even among wealthy countries. In Denmark, about 42% of firms with ten or more employees use AI, roughly double the EU-27 average of about 20%. At the other end, adoption is in the single digits in countries such as Romania, Türkiye and Canada.

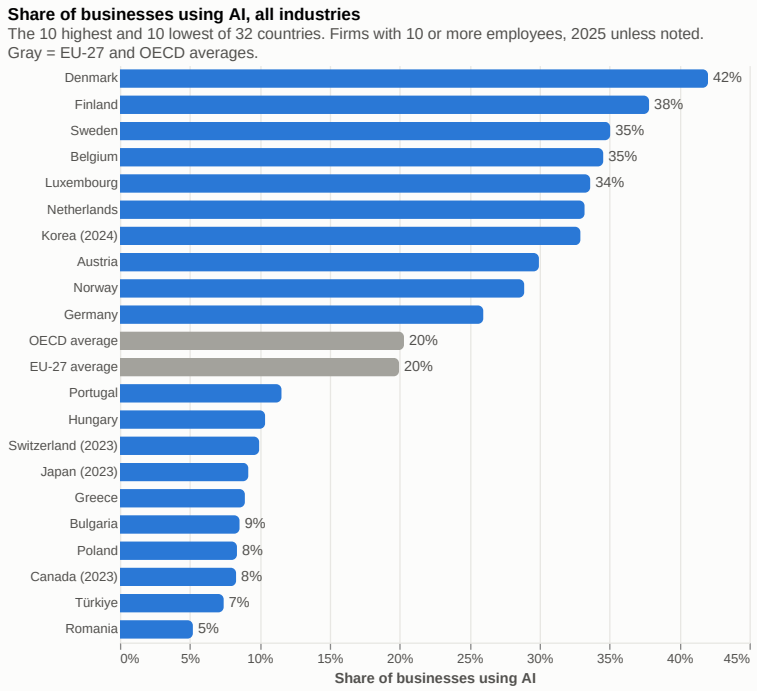


Figure 5. Share of businesses using AI, the 10 highest and 10 lowest countries in the OECD survey.
Source: OECD, ICT Access and Usage by Businesses.

Countries with higher GDP per capita tend to adopt more, but the relationship is only moderate (r = 0.45). Countries with similar output per person differ widely: Denmark and Finland adopt far more than Switzerland or Ireland. Income sets the stage, but it does not determine adoption.

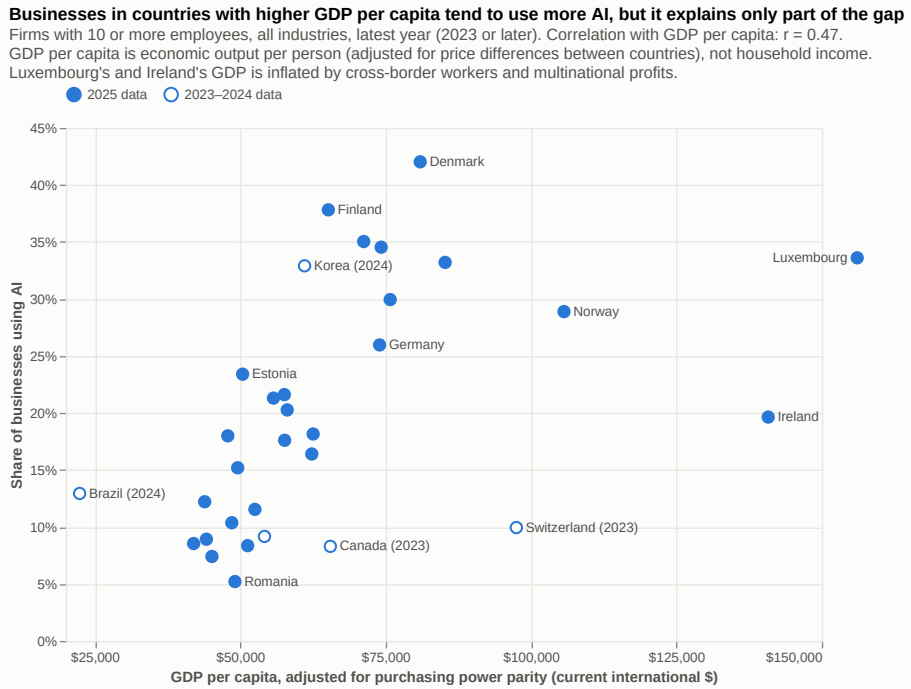


Figure 6. AI adoption against GDP per capita (adjusted for purchasing power parity).
Source: OECD, ICT Access and Usage by Businesses; World Bank, World Development Indicators.

Within countries, the divide runs along firm size. Large firms are far more likely to use AI than small ones in every country, and the gap is widest among the leading adopters.

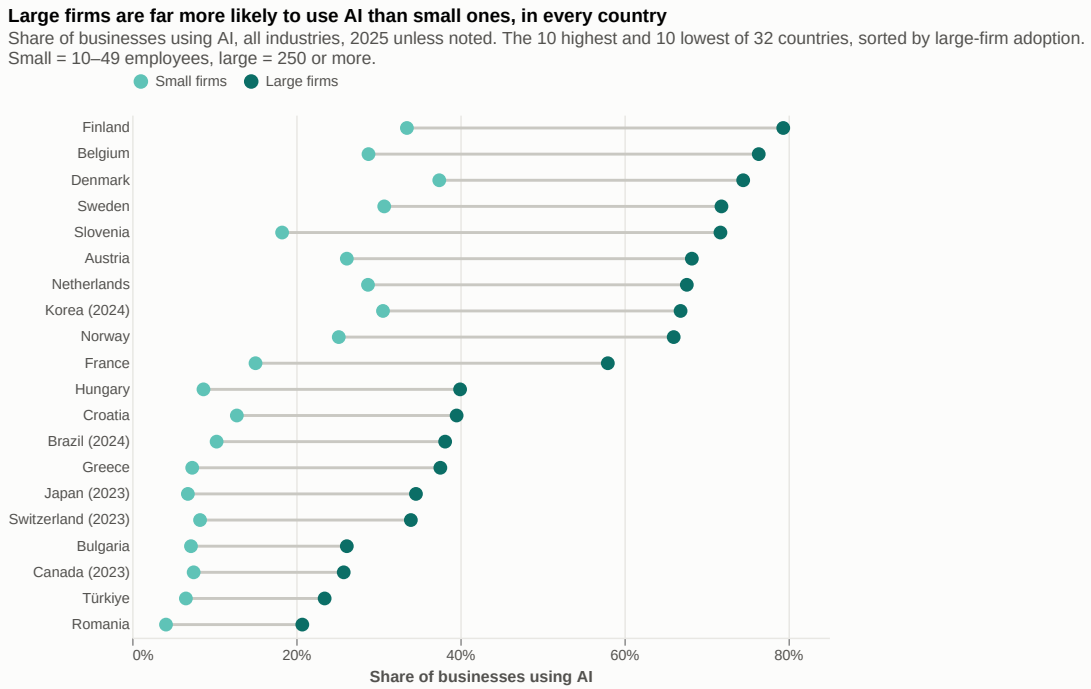


Figure 7. AI use in small (10–49 employees) and large (250+) firms.
Source: OECD, ICT Access and Usage by Businesses.

Adoption also depends heavily on the industry. Information and communication firms are by far the heaviest users, followed by professional and scientific services, while construction, transport, and hotels and food service lag well behind.

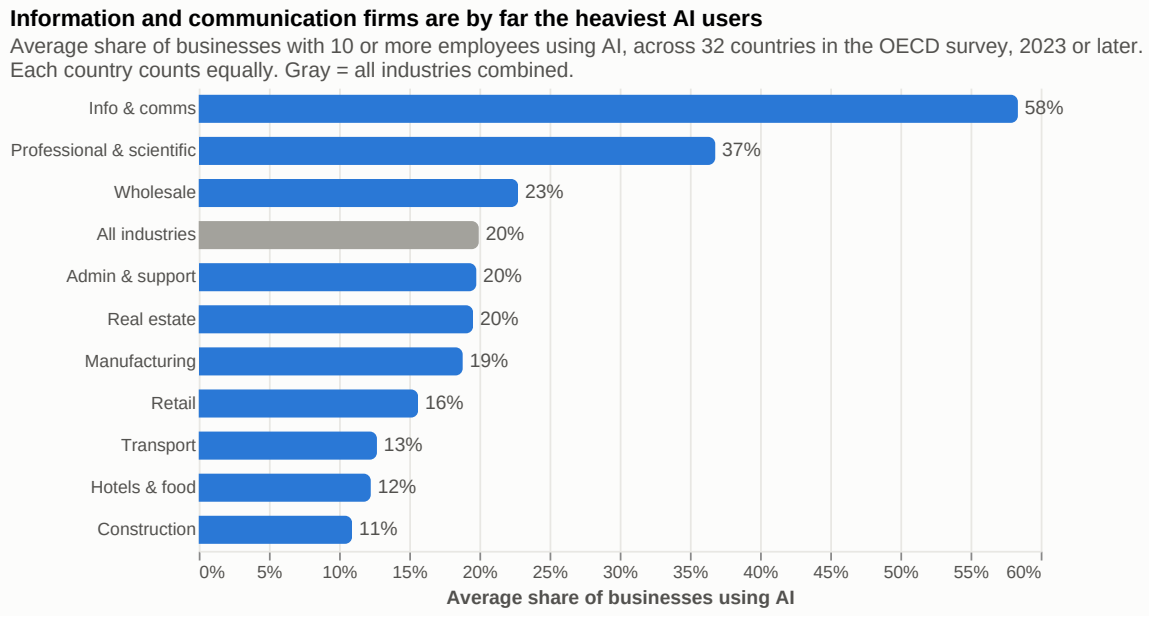


Figure 8. Average share of businesses using AI by industry, across countries in the OECD survey.
Source: OECD, ICT Access and Usage by Businesses.

3. What this means

The data point to a layered divide rather than a simple one. Exposure is concentrated in high-income countries, in office work, and among women. Adoption, where it can be measured, also rises with income, but varies widely among countries at similar income levels, between large and small firms, and between industries. Among the countries where both can be observed, the most exposed workforces are not systematically the slowest adopters; the larger gap may be between large digital-sector firms and everyone else.

Limitations. The OECD adoption survey covers about 30 countries, mostly in Europe, while the occupation data cover much of the world, so the two can only be compared for a small, high-income set of countries. Adoption in low- and middle-income countries remains largely unmeasured. Clerical share is a proxy for exposure, and exposure is not impact. Adoption figures from before 2023 are excluded because generative AI spread after late 2022, and each country's latest year differs.

Data and sources

ILO, ILOSTAT: employment by sex and occupation (ISCO-08 major groups).
Gmyrek, P., Berg, J., et al. (2025). *Generative AI and Jobs: A Refined Global Index of Occupational Exposure*. ILO Working Paper 140.
OECD, ICT Access and Usage by Businesses database: share of enterprises using AI.
World Bank, World Development Indicators: GDP per capita, PPP (current international $); country income classifications.
Map boundaries: Natural Earth, via vega-datasets.